with Humayun, the Uzbeks were highly ranked and prized; and their contribution to the conquest of Hindustan and the expansion of the realm fully justified their favoured position.

On the other hand, the Uzbeks were warlords, powerful and proud. Ali Quli and his brother Bahadur, for example, were very unhappy with Bairam's overthrow, and furious with how his supporters were treated. One of these was Wali Beg, Bairam's brother-in-law, and procurer of Akbar's first cheetah. Wali Beg was killed during the coup against Bairam, and his head sent to the eastern provinces. When the butchered head of his friend arrived in Bahadur's fief, he was so incensed, he cut off the messenger's head.

Clearly, the Uzbek brothers were not to be messed with; following her coup against Bairam, the powerful Maham Anaka was concerned enough about their displeasure to offer Ali Quli the rank of vakil.[35] Over the next few years, the Uzbeks' power would only increase. Just before the rebellion, as Afzal Husain explains it, Uzbeks held two large chunks of the empire, Malwa and the east, and were beginning to develop ties with neighbouring kings, in Gujarat, Rohtas, Bihar and Bengal.

Akbar, meanwhile, was increasingly disinclined to treat these warlords with either Maham's kid gloves or Bairam's friendship – let alone Humayun's trust. Already, long ago, he had meddled in Ali Quli's love life, and things were only getting worse: now, he was demanding account of their revenue and their administration – chasing Abdullah Khan Uzbek out of Malwa and going over Ali Quli Shaibani's head in dealing with Rohtas.

Thus, the two sides arrived at a point of no return. Just as the Uzbeks were settling down to become the kind of virtually independent rulers that Humayun had imagined managing his realm, Akbar was making it ever more clear that Hindustan would have one lord, and one lord alone: the padishah himself.[36]

It was a fundamental misunderstanding of roles that could only be resolved by war.

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Akbar set himself to work 'from early morning till the end of day' on preparing an army, which included selecting the 2000 elephants, no less,